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Bola Tinubu (tee-NOO-boo)

President
Federal Republic of of Nigeria

Addressed as: **Mr. President** | Office held since: **May 2023**

Bola Tinubu is a seasoned political operator who is betting that his deal-making skills will eventually stabilize Nigeria's economy and restore its leadership role in Africa and the world.

- **A Political Godfather**
  A former senator and governor, Tinubu has translated his control of southwestern Nigerian politics into national power. He is a mentor to many politicians and helped establish the ruling All Progressives Congress (APC), which has held the presidency since 2015 and currently controls 29 out of 36 states.

- **An Economic Reformer**
  Tinubu is seeking to transform his country's economy, replicating the success he had when he governed Lagos, Nigeria's commercial capital. He has instituted major reforms, including floating the currency and removing fuel subsidies, that have been long prescribed by experts, but remain controversial and unpopular at home.

Tinubu, who is also known as Asiwaju ("champion" in Yoruba), believes he is entitled to lead his country. His presidential campaign slogan was "emi lo kan" (meaning "It's my turn" in Yoruba).

WHY THEY MATTER

Tinubu has a generally positive stance towards foreign companies involved in banking and finance, seeing them as key for Nigeria's economic growth.

- **Forex Reforms and Repatriation**
  In addition to floating the currency, he has reassured foreign companies that they would face no issues in repatriating their funds. He told Coca Cola executives that "we are building a financial system where you can invest, re-invest, and repatriate all your dividends."

- **Courting Global Capital**
  Tinubu has attracted high-profile endorsements from diaspora billionaires. In September 2025, BlackRock senior managing director Bayo Ogunlesi pledged billions in investments in Nigeria's energy, aviation, and port sectors, calling the country "investable for the first time in years" after what he described as a "fundamental transformation" of the economy.

Tinubu has set the target of building a $1 trillion economy by 2030 by attracting massive foreign investment, particularly in technology and manufacturing.

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MEETING WITH THEM

Tinubu employs a warm, engaging demeanor in meetings, relying heavily on his charisma, past record, and broad vision statements to convey his main points, rather than detailed policy positions.

- **Broad Vision**
  Tinubu talks at a high level about his goals and values, emphasizing why his government's policies are straightforward and commonsensical based on Nigeria's importance in Africa and the international community.

- **Personal Appeals**
  Personal relationships hold great value for Tinubu, and he may reference shared acquaintances or past interactions to establish common ground. The president often tries to impart advice "as a friend" and will stress that he and his counterpart have the same goals.

Tinubu uses uncommon aphorisms and colorful metaphors to underscore his point, warning that "a blind man [who] loves his dog is in trouble" and if "you want to wrestle with the pig, you have to live with dirt."

ON THEIR MIND

- **2026 Budget Signed**
  President Tinubu in December signed the ₦58.18 trillion 2026 budget, describing it as "a reset, a very hard one." He vowed to end the practice of running multiple budgets on a single revenue cycle: "From April, Nigeria will operate on a single budget backed by a single revenue cycle—no overlaps, no excuses, no rollovers.

- **Economic Turnaround**
  Nigeria's economy recorded GDP growth of 4.23 percent in Q2 2025—the highest in four years—while inflation dropped below 15 percent by late 2025, down from over 30 percent in 2024. The country received credit rating upgrades from Moody's, Fitch, and Standard & Poor's in 2025.

- **Managing U.S. Frictions**
  The State Department’s Undersecretary for Political Affairs in mid-January visited Nigeria as part of the U.S.-Nigeria Binational Commission. Her trip came on the heels of the recall of the U.S. Ambassador and U.S. military strikes in northwest Nigeria on Christmas.

- **Looming Hunger Crisis**
  The World Food Program recently indicated that more than a million people in northeastern Nigeria could lose access to emergency food and nutrition aid within weeks unless funding is secured, as violence and hunger surge in the region.

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NETWORK

Tinubu is seeking to redirect U.S. President Trump's false narrative about Christian persecution into greater security cooperation, while continuing to press UK, European, Gulf, and Chinese governments and investors to support his economic agenda.

In response to President Trump's threat to deploy the U.S. military "'guns-a-blazing" to address allegations of Christian persecution, Tinubu deployed his team to engage with senior U.S. policymakers in late 2025 as well as hired a lobbying firm. Tinubu claims his government worked with the United States to plan and execute military strikes on Christmas day.

Tinubu has cultivated an extensive network of political allies, business elites, and technocrats across Nigeria, particularly in the southwest. He maintains strong ties to loyal politicians who depend on his patronage, but also is quick to make amends with former foes.

Tinubu has installed his closest associates in economic positions, including Finance Minister Wale Edun and Central Bank Governor Yemi Cardoso. He also trusts his Chief of Staff Femi Gbajabiamila.

CONTROVERSIES

Tinubu's presidency has been shadowed by a web of controversies that have followed him throughout his political career. Moreover, his economic reforms have spurred nationwide protests.

- **Corruption Allegations**
  Critics have long accused Tinubu of amassing wealth through opaque business dealings and political kickbacks. There has been scrutiny around his son Seyi's London property, which was purchased through an offshore company.

- **Health Status and Foreign Travel**
  Questions about Tinubu's health have intensified, fueled by frequent trips abroad. By September 2025, he had made 15 international trips that year alone, spending at least 59 days across eight visits to France since taking office. Critics allege these trips are for medical treatment; the presidency maintains they are working visits and vacations.

Tinubu has been dogged by questions about his time in the United States, including whether he possessed a fraudulent diploma from Chicago State University in 1979 and allegations about his involvement in drug trafficking in the 1990s.

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CAREER HIGHLIGHTS

- **President**, Federal Republic of Nigeria (2023 to present)
- **Co-Founder**, All Progressives Congress (APC) (2013)
- **Governor**, Lagos State (1999 to 2007)
- **Senator (Representing Lagos West)**, Nigerian Senate (1992-1993)
- **Accountant**, Arthur Andersen, Deloitte, and Mobil (1980s)

BIO

Tinubu's personal and professional life mirrors the multicultural, entrepreneurial, and boisterous ethos of Lagos. Born on March 29, 1952, Tinubu's mother was a renowned trader and his wife is a former senator and ordained minister. While he is Muslim, they have raised their six children as Christian; one of his sons died of cardiac arrest at age 37.

- **Formative Years in Chicago**
  Tinubu worked as a security guard, taxi driver, and dishwasher, while earning a degree in accounting from Chicago State University in 1979. He worked for Deloitte and Arthur Andersen before returning home.

- **Democracy Activism in Nigeria**
  Tinubu became a member of the pro-democracy group, the National Democratic Coalition (NADECO) to fight military rule in the 1990s. He was briefly jailed before going into exile in 1994.

Tinubu speaks Yoruba and English fluently, and enjoys watching football, especially when the Super Eagles, Nigeria's national football team, are on the pitch.